

Robert Charles Goodwin

Red Bluff, 4 January 1925 · San Mateo County, 13 March 2014. A Sacramento Valley boy raised in Eureka, San Francisco and Burlingame by his mother and the stepfather he called father; a nineteen-year-old pump station operator on the longest military pipeline of the Second World War, from Assam through Burma toward China; a brake man and mechanic on the Peninsula for the rest of his life; the father of Susan and Betty, and the grandfather whose first name Bobby carries.

Compiled 4 September 2026 for Robert Anthony Goodwin and Elizabeth Lenora Goodwin by Grace Marie Goodwin, from the census, the Army's records, the county recorder, the city directories and the newspapers. A companion to the family page, Goodwin & Oviatt Lines.

89 years, 1925 to 2014	2 y 9 m in the Army, 1943 to 1946	721 days overseas	3 campaigns: India-Burma, Central Burma, China Defensive
11 addresses traced, Red Bluff to Norfolk Street	2 daughters, Susan and Betty		



Myitkyina, Burma, 10 August 1944. Men of Robert's company, the 775th Engineer Petroleum Distribution Company, unload pipe flown in from India from a C-47, a week after the town fell. U.S. Air Force photograph, National Archives.

TEN CHAPTERS

The life, in order

Everything below rests on a record named in the sources at the end; where the records fall silent, the text says so.

RED BLUFF, 4 JANUARY 1925

A Foley grandson in the Sacramento Valley

Robert Charles Goodwin was born on 4 January 1925 at Red Bluff, the county seat of Tehama County in California's upper Sacramento Valley, the second child and first son of Charles Herbert Goodwin and Lenora Augusta Foley. His father, born in a Kansas sod house in 1897 and raised in the logging country of Washington, had come to Red Bluff with his parents about 1917, gone to the Army in the World War, and married seventeen-year-old Nora Foley in the Catholic church there on 21 November 1921. His mother was the third of nine children of Pinkney Foley, a Kentucky-Missouri farmer's son who had come to Red Bluff in 1897, and Mary Clara DeRose, whose parents had come from the Portuguese islands of Pico and Madeira. Robert was named Robert for no one that the records show and Charles for his father; the name would pass to his grandson.

The only photograph of him as a child is the Foley family portrait taken about 1925 under a tree at Red Bluff. His father stands at the left holding his sister Dolores, who was born in August 1923; his mother stands at the right with the baby in her arms, beside her own mother, Mary DeRose Foley, and between them stand Nora's brothers Victor, Phillip, Joaquin and Angelo in overalls and her sisters Cecelia and Lucille. He was two years old when the family began to move for work: his brother Harold Philip was born at Cottage Grove in the Oregon timber country on 8 December 1926, and his sister Patricia Mae at Eureka, on the Humboldt coast, on 31 May 1928.



About 1925, Red Bluff: Charles Goodwin holding Dolores at left, Nora holding baby Robert at right beside her mother Mary DeRose Foley, and Nora's brothers and sisters between them.

EUREKA, 1930

J Street, and a household without a father

The 1930 census found the family at 539 J Street in Eureka, and it tells the story of the marriage in a single column. Nora, 25, is written down as head of the household; her husband is not in the house. With her are Dolores, 6, Robert, 5, Harold, 3, and Patricia, 1, and boarding with them are Charles's brother Albert Goodwin, 26, and Albert's small son Eugene. Charles was elsewhere, and the marriage

was over in all but name. A cousin's family tree places him at Summit City in Shasta County, the construction camp for Shasta Dam, by 1942; he married again, to Susie Marie Jones, and after her death in 1969 to Jane Beggs, and died at Martinez in 1985 at 88. He and Robert lived within an hour of each other for most of their adult lives; whether they saw each other the records do not say.

On 5 May 1933, at Gold Beach on the Oregon coast, Nora married Joseph Perry Rocha, a Humboldt County man of Azorean parents born at Arcata in 1904. Robert was eight. From then on Joseph Rocha was his father in every practical sense, and the two men kept faith with that for forty years: Robert's draft card in 1943 names 'Mr. Joseph P. Rocha (father)' as the person who would always know where he was; the 1950 census lists him in Joseph's house as a stepson; and when Joseph died in 1973 his obituary counted 'two sons, Robert and Harold Goodwin, both of San Mateo.'

SAN FRANCISCO, 1935 TO 1940

Shotwell Street

By 1935 the Rochas had moved to San Francisco, and on 1 April 1940 the census taker found them at 517 Shotwell Street in the Mission District: Lanora Rocha, 35, with Dolores, 16, Robert, 15, Harold, 13, and Patricia, 11. Robert was in the eighth grade at fifteen, a year or two behind, which fits a childhood spent moving between Red Bluff, Oregon, Eureka and the city. He would finish three years of high school, his Army papers say, and no more; the war came first.

BURLINGAME, 1941 TO 1943

Channing Road and the tire shop

The family settled on the Peninsula, at 14 Channing Road in Burlingame, a few blocks from the Southern Pacific station. Joseph Rocha was a partner in the Panko and Rocha Tire Company, with its shop at 247 California Drive, and Robert went to work for him there. The first time his name appears in a newspaper is as an usher: on Saturday, 6 June 1942, the afternoon the news from Midway was still coming in, his sister Dolores married John Matthew Farrell Jr. at St. Catherine's Church in Burlingame, in white satin with a cluster of gardenias, given away by Mr. Rocha, and the San Mateo Times reported that 'ushers were Robert Goodwin and Edward Reininger.' The bride, the paper noted, 'has one sister, Patricia, and two brothers, Robert and Harold,' and among the guests were Mrs. Mary Lorenzo of Arcata and Mrs. Evelyn Costa of Red Bluff, the Rocha and Foley connections come down for the day.

Seven months later, on 4 January 1943, Robert turned eighteen and registered for the draft the same day. The card survives, filled out in his own hand: Robert Charles Goodwin, 14 Channing Road, Burlingame, telephone Burlingame 3-2125, born Red Bluff, employed by Joseph P. Rocha at 247 California Drive. Local Board 104 in San Mateo called him up within three months.

REGISTRATION CARD (Men born on or after July 1, 1924, and on or before December 31, 1924.) (Also for the registration of men as they reach the 18th anniversary of the date of their birth on or after January 1, 1943.)		STAMP APPROVED Registry Bureau No. 12-2018-43
SERIAL NUMBER W. 88	1. NAME (Print) Robert Charles Goodwin	ORDER NUMBER 13092
2. PLACE OF BIRTH (Print) 14 Channing Rd Burlingame Sm. Calif. (THE PLACE OF RESIDENCE GIVEN ON LINE 2 ABOVE WILL DETERMINE LOCAL BOARD JURISDICTION; LINE 3 OF REGISTRATION CERTIFICATE WILL BE IDENTICAL)		
3. MAILING ADDRESS Same		
4. TELEPHONE Blyme 32125	5. AGE IN YEARS 18	6. PLACE OF BIRTH Red Bluff
7. DATE OF BIRTH Jan 4 1925		
8. NAME AND ADDRESS OF EMPLOYER WHO WILL ALWAYS KNOW YOUR ADDRESS Joseph P. Rocha (father) 14 Channing Rd Burlingame		
9. EMPLOYER'S NAME AND ADDRESS Joseph P. Rocha		
10. PLACE OF EMPLOYMENT OR BUSINESS 247 California Dr Blyme Sm. Calif.		
I AFFIRM THAT I HAVE FURNISHED ABOVE ANSWERS AND THAT THEY ARE TRUE.		
DRAFT BOARD 1 (Rev. 11-10-42)		410-91020-4 (OVER) Robert Goodwin

Robert's draft registration card, filled out on his eighteenth birthday, 4 January 1943, in his own hand: 14 Channing Road, Burlingame; employer Joseph P. Rocha, 247 California Drive; and 'Mr. Joseph P. Rocha (father)' as the man who would always know his address.

SAN FRANCISCO TO INDIA, 1943 TO 1944

Private Goodwin, 39130554

He was inducted into the Army of the United States at San Francisco on 9 April 1943, a 'selectee, single, without dependents,' with three years of high school and, in the clerk's words, the civilian occupation of 'student, high school, academic.' The Army gave him serial number 39130554, carried him for a week in the inactive Enlisted Reserve Corps, and put him on active duty on 16 April. On 26 May 1943 he qualified as a marksman with the .30-caliber rifle. His training was as a pump station operator, military occupational specialty 220, and his branch was the Corps of Engineers.

On 11 January 1944 he sailed for the Asiatic-Pacific Theater and on 8 February 1944, after four weeks at sea, he landed in India. He was nineteen. He would not see the United States again for nearly two years.

ASSAM, BURMA AND CHINA, 1944 TO 1945

The pump station operator on the Ledo Road

His unit was the 775th Engineer Petroleum Distribution Company. The petroleum distribution companies of the China-Burma-India theater built and ran the longest military pipeline of the war: four- and six-inch pipe laid beside the Ledo Road from the Assam oilfields at Digboi across the Patkai mountains and through the jungle of northern Burma, joined in 1945 to the old Burma Road and pushed on to Kunming in China. Pumping stations were spaced along its length to lift the aviation gasoline, motor fuel and diesel over the passes and keep it moving, and running one of those stations was Robert's job.

The National Archives holds one photograph of his company at work. It was taken on 10 August 1944 at Myitkyina, the Japanese-held airfield and river town in north Burma that General Stilwell's Chinese and American troops had besieged since May; the town fell on 3 August. A week later, men of the 775th are standing in the monsoon mud beside a Douglas C-47 of a combat cargo squadron, unloading lengths of pipe that had been flown over from India, because there was as yet no road on which to bring them. That is the



Men of Robert's company, the 775th Engineer Petroleum Distribution Company, unloading pipe sections from a Douglas C-47 of a combat cargo squadron at Myitkyina, Burma, 10 August 1944, a week after the town fell. The pipe was flown in from India. U.S. Air Force photograph 123481AC, National Archives.

pipeline advancing into Burma behind the front, and Robert, six months in the theater, was one of the men doing it. His discharge credits him with three campaigns, India-Burma, Central Burma and China Defensive, which trace the pipeline's own progress down the Ledo Road, across the Irrawaddy country, and toward China in 1945; whether he ever crossed the border himself the records do not say. By 2 September 1945, the day Japan signed the surrender, his Adjusted Service Rating score, the points system that decided who went home first, stood at 64.

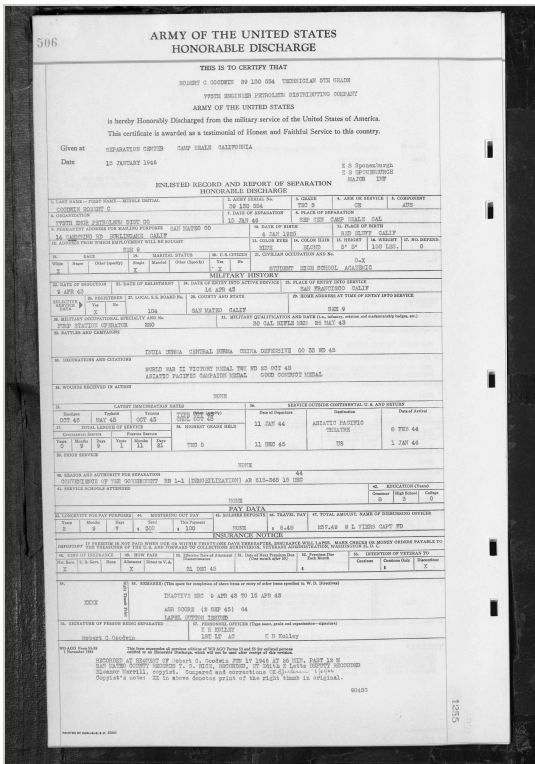
He left the theater on 11 December 1945 and reached the United States on New Year's Day 1946. Two weeks later, on 15 January 1946, he was honorably discharged at the Separation Center at Camp Beale, north of Sacramento, a Technician Fifth Grade, a corporal's rank for a specialist's job. The Enlisted Record and Report of Separation that he took home, and had copied into the San Mateo County records on 17 June 1946, sets down the whole of it: two years, nine months and seven days of service, of which one year, eleven months and twenty-one days were overseas; the Asiatic-Pacific Campaign Medal, the Good Conduct Medal and the World War II Victory Medal; wounds received in action, none; five feet five inches, 150 pounds, blue eyes, blond hair; \$300 in mustering-out pay, \$100 of it in hand, and \$8.48 for the trip home to 14 Channing Road. He signed it Robert C Goodwin, and the copyist noted that the original carried the print of his right thumb.

BURLINGAME, 1946 TO 1950

Brake repairman

He went back to Channing Road and back to the tire shop. The Burlingame city directories list him in 1946, 1947 and 1948, and the census taker who called at the Rocha house on 14 Channing Road in April 1950 wrote him down as 25, single, a brake repairman at a tire sales and repair station, working a 35-hour week, in a household of four: Joseph P. Rocha, 45, head, a business proprietor and partner; Lenora, 45; Robert, stepson; and Patricia, 21, stepdaughter, a bookkeeper.

The census taker was behind the news. Robert had met Peggy Lou Fergon, born Peggy Lou Miller at Pierre, South Dakota, in 1926, a sergeant's daughter who had come to the Peninsula as the wife of a San Mateo airman, Rodney Fergon, and had two small sons by him. Her husband had published the customary notice in the San Mateo Times in January 1949 that he would no longer be responsible for her debts. On 18 February 1950 Peggy gave birth to a daughter in Santa Cruz County, Susan Lenora, named for Robert's mother. Ten days later, on 28 February 1950, Robert C. Goodwin and Peggy Fergon were married at Carson City, Nevada, where a couple could marry the day they arrived. When the census taker came to Channing Road five weeks after that, whoever answered the door said Robert was single.



The Honorable Discharge and Enlisted Record, Camp Beale, 15 January 1946, recorded in San Mateo County on 17 June 1946 at Robert's own request.

REDWOOD CITY, 1951 TO 1954

Peggy, Susan and Betty

The Goodwins set up house in Redwood City. Their second daughter, Elizabeth Anne, was born there on 29 May 1951; she has been Betty all her life, and she is Bobby's mother. The 1953 Redwood City directory has the family at 221 Alameda de las Pulgas, Robert a mechanic, Peggy beside him in the parentheses that directories reserve for a wife. It is the last record that shows them together. The marriage ended in the middle 1950s, on a date and in a courtroom the indexes do not reach; by 1956 Robert was living at Channing Road again, and in December 1959 Peggy married Marvin Sumner in Las Vegas and moved to Garden Farms in San Luis Obispo County, where she died in 1979. Susan and Betty grew up as Goodwins on the Peninsula, in their father's and grandmother's houses.

Peggy's obituary in 1979 named them first among her children, 'Susan Inch of Boulder Creek and Betty Goodwin of San Mateo,' and when Marvin Sumner died in 2005 his obituary still listed 'Susan Inch of Boulder Creek and Betty Smith of San Mateo' among his stepchildren. Susan lived at Boulder Creek in the Santa Cruz Mountains and died a few years ago.

SAN MATEO, 1956 TO 2014

The Norfolk Street years

The San Mateo city directories carry Robert through the next quarter century almost year by year. In 1956 he is at Channing Road in Burlingame, a 'brake representative,' a salesman's title in the trade he had learned at the tire shop. By 1962 he had his own address, 753 South Norfolk Street in San Mateo, and by 1977 the directory gives it as 1753 South Norfolk Street, telephone 341-5485; the public records index still has him at 1753 South Norfolk in 1993, so that house on the east side of San Mateo, near the bay, was his home for at least thirty years and probably to the end. In 1965, 1966 and 1968 the directories put a 'Betty' with him: his daughter Elizabeth, then a teenager, living at home. In 1969 he is a mechanic again, working for Dick Bullis, the San Mateo car dealer.

On 26 October 1969, at 44, he married Laverne P. Codoni, 40, in San Mateo; the directories of 1974 and 1976 list them together, and the state index records their divorce in San Mateo County in February 1981. His stepfather Joseph Rocha died at Mills Hospital in February 1973, at 68, and the San Mateo Times obituary named Robert among his sons. His mother Nora lived on in Burlingame to 93, dying in January 1998; she and Joseph lie together under a shared bronze marker at Skylawn Memorial Park on the ridge above San Mateo, and his sister Patricia, who never married and died in 2015, is in the same section. His father Charles died in Martinez in 1985; his sister Dolores Farrell in 2009; his brother Harold in 2002.

Robert Charles Goodwin died on 13 March 2014, at 89, the last of Nora's children but one. A cousin's family tree places the death at Burlingame, where his life on the Peninsula had begun seventy years before. His grandson Robert Anthony Goodwin, Bobby, born in 1983, carries his first name, and Bobby's daughter Elizabeth Lenora carries his mother's and his daughter's.

What is still to be found

No obituary or burial record for Robert has yet been found; the San Mateo Daily Journal, the paper most likely to have carried a notice in March 2014, is not in the online archives, and he has no Find a Grave memorial, which may mean cremation. No photograph of him as an adult has surfaced in the public trees; the family may hold the only ones. The 775th Engineer Petroleum Distribution Company's own records, its morning reports and unit history, are at the National Archives and the National Personnel Records Center in St. Louis and would say which pump stations on the Assam-Burma-China line were his, and whether he went into China. The San Mateo County Superior Court holds the file of his divorce from Peggy, which would date the end of that marriage. And anyone in the family who remembers Bob Goodwin of Norfolk Street, mechanic, veteran of the Ledo Road, could add more to this page than any archive.

1921 TO 2014

Timeline

1921	Charles Herbert Goodwin, 24, marries Nora Foley, 17, at Red Bluff, 21 November	1933	Nora marries Joseph Perry Rocha at Gold Beach, Oregon, 5 May; Robert is eight
1923	Sister Dolores born, Tehama County, 28 August	1935	The family moves to San Francisco
1925	Robert Charles Goodwin born at Red Bluff, 4 January	1940	Census: 517 Shotwell Street, San Francisco; Robert, 15, in the eighth grade
1926	Brother Harold Philip born at Cottage Grove, Oregon, 8 December	1942	Usher at his sister Dolores's wedding, St. Catherine's, Burlingame, 6 June
1928	Sister Patricia Mae born in Humboldt County, 31 May	1943	Registers for the draft on his eighteenth birthday, 4 January; inducted at San Francisco, 9 April; active duty 16 April; rifle marksman 26 May
1930	Census: 539 J Street, Eureka; mother head of the household, father absent		

1944	Sails 11 January; lands in India 8 February; his company photographed unloading pipe at Myitkyina, Burma, 10 August
1945	Campaigns: India-Burma, Central Burma, China Defensive; leaves the theater 11 December
1946	Lands in the United States 1 January; discharged at Camp Beale as Technician Fifth Grade, 15 January; discharge recorded in San Mateo County, 17 June
1946–48	Burlingame city directories, 14 Channing Road
1950	Daughter Susan Lenora born in Santa Cruz County, 18 February; marries Peggy Fergon at Carson City, 28 February; census lists him single at Channing Road, brake repairman
1951	Daughter Elizabeth Anne, 'Betty', born at Redwood City, 29 May
1953	Redwood City directory: 221 Alameda de las Pulgas, mechanic, with Peggy
1956	San Mateo directory: back at Channing Road, Burlingame, brake representative

1959	Peggy marries Marvin Sumner in Las Vegas, 8 December
1962	753 South Norfolk Street, San Mateo, representative
1965–68	Directories list 'Betty' with him at home
1969	Mechanic at Dick Bullis, San Mateo; marries Laverne P. Codoni, 26 October
1973	Stepfather Joseph Rocha dies, 8 February; the obituary names Robert as his son
1977	1753 South Norfolk Street, San Mateo
1979	Peggy dies at Garden Farms, 27 January
1981	Divorce from Laverne, San Mateo County, February
1983	Grandson Robert Anthony Goodwin born
1985	Father Charles dies at Martinez, 12 October
1993	Still at 1753 South Norfolk Street
1998	Mother Nora Rocha dies in Burlingame, 13 January, aged 93
2014	Robert Charles Goodwin dies, 13 March, aged 89

DOCUMENTS AND PHOTOGRAPHS

The paper trail



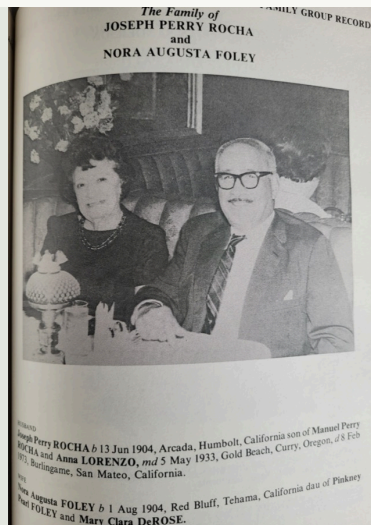
About 1925: the Foley family at Red Bluff, with Nora holding baby Robert at the right.

Draft registration card, 4 January 1943, in Robert's hand.



The 775th Engineer Petroleum Distribution Company unloading pipe from a C-47 at Myitkyina, Burma, 10 August 1944. National Archives, 342-FH-3A37002-123481AC.

Honorable Discharge and Enlisted Record and Report of Separation, Camp Beale, 15 January 1946.



Joseph and Nora Rocha, the parents of the Channing Road house.



Patricia Mae Goodwin (1928-2015), Robert's sister, at Skylawn Memorial Park.

RECORDS

Sources

- California Birth Index (Robert Charles Goodwin, 4 January 1925, Tehama County); Michelle Smith Family Tree on Ancestry (birth at Red Bluff, death 2014 at Burlingame)
- 1930 United States census, Eureka, Humboldt County, 539 J Street (Ancestry)

3. 1940 United States census, San Francisco, 517 Shotwell Street (Ancestry)
4. San Mateo Times, 6 June 1942, p. 4: 'Goodwin-Farrell Ceremony at St. Catherine's Church' (Newspapers.com)
5. World War II draft registration card, 4 January 1943 (family copy; FamilySearch)
6. U.S., World War II Army Enlistment Records, 1938–1946: Robert C. Goodwin, serial 39130554, 9 April 1943 (Ancestry)
7. California, Military Discharges, 1856–1965: Enlisted Record and Report of Separation, WD AGO Form 53-55, recorded San Mateo County 17 June 1946 (FamilySearch film 005084401, image 507)
8. National Archives, Record Group 342, U.S. Air Force photograph 123481AC: members of the 775th Engineer Petroleum Distribution Company at Myitkyina, 10 August 1944 (NAID 204968074)
9. 1950 United States census, Burlingame, household of Joseph P. Rocha (FamilySearch and Ancestry)
10. Carson City, Nevada, Marriage Index, 1855–1985: Robert C. Goodwin and Peggy Fergon, 28 February 1950 (Ancestry)
11. California Birth Index: Susan Lenora Goodwin, 18 February 1950, Santa Cruz County; Elizabeth Anne Goodwin, 29 May 1951, San Mateo County; mother's maiden name Miller
12. U.S. City Directories, 1822–1995: Burlingame 1946–1948; Redwood City 1953; San Mateo 1955–1977 (Ancestry)
13. San Mateo Times, 13 January 1949, p. 18 (Rodney Fergon's notice); 9 February 1973, p. 31 (obituary of Joseph P. Rocha) (Newspapers.com)
14. California Marriage Index, 1960–1985: Robert C. Goodwin and Laverne P. Codoni, San Mateo, 26 October 1969; California Divorce Index, 1966–1984: February 1981 (Ancestry)
15. U.S. Public Records Index, 1950–1993: 1753 S. Norfolk Street, San Mateo (Ancestry)
16. San Luis Obispo Telegram-Tribune, 29 January 1979 (obituary of Peggy Lou Sumner); The Tribune, 23 February 2005 (obituary of Marvon Eugene Sumner) (Newspapers.com)
17. Fold3 memorial, Robert C. Goodwin, U.S. Army, died 13 March 2014 (Ancestry)
18. FamilySearch Family Tree, Robert Charles Goodwin GHLM-CTK

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